

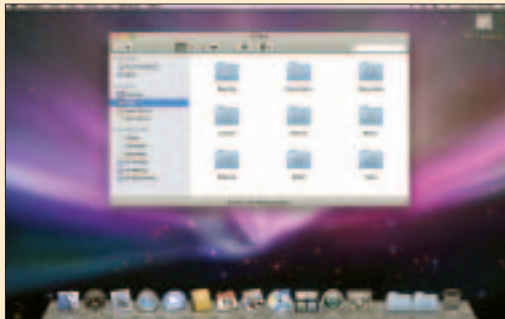
Windows weaknesses

That's not Vista's only downside, either. Despite the huge influx of features and options, there are still many areas in which Windows is curiously lacking. The most obvious oversight is Vista's absence of built-in anti-virus protection. Other areas, such as hard disk maintenance tools and office applications, are still somewhat weak, too. On top of that, many of Vista's much-touted cosmetic elements can slow down performance, especially on older PCs, while some peripherals and software that worked with XP may run into problems when used with Vista. In fact, with a little know-how it's easy to plug these gaps and iron out performance and compatibility problems. We'll be doing just that later on.

Other operating systems

There are two major alternatives to Windows; Mac OSX, available only for Apple Mac computers, and Linux, which is an open source OS available for anyone to download and install for free and comes in the shape of a number of different user interfaces – known as 'distros'.

Both OSs easily equal Windows Vista in terms of the number of built-in features and functions. The latest version of OSX (OSX 10.5 or 'Leopard'), for example, comes with some very handy extras, such as Time Machine (a visual backup utility) and Back to my Mac (which allows you to access your home computer over the internet). Linux distros like Ubuntu



Mac OSX and Linux offer similar features to Vista

(www.ubuntu.com) go one step further. As well as including a vast number of utilities and applications from the get-go (including a full office suite), further features can be added at will – and for free –

With so many features, utilities, settings and options tucked away in every corner, it's only natural that people coming to the OS for the first time might not initially recognise Vista's full potential. And that's precisely where we pick up the story. It is our aim to both uncover Windows Vista features you may not know about and show you how to get more from the features you are already familiar with. We want to make sure you maximise your possibilities and put you in charge of your PC, whether you're exploring new avenues, getting to grips with the basics, sorting out a problem or just setting your computer up so it works the way you want it to.